Write Down the Everyday Life Your Father Would Want Care to Keep

Four prompts to start an easy conversation, turn it into a map of his routines, catch what you've left out, and record it in a way that expects to change.

Where you are

Your father lives on his own and does fine. He has his ways: the same cafe on Thursdays, the news at six, the garden before it gets hot. Nothing needs to change, and that's exactly why it's a good time to write down what he'd want kept if someday it did.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You have one page, in his words wherever possible, describing what an ordinary good day holds for him, who matters in it, and how he lets people know when he'd rather not, dated so you know when to ask again.

A one-page Ordinary Day profile for your father: Mornings, Meals, Afternoons and activities, People, Evenings and sleep, How he says no, with the date it was written and a date to check it again.

Before you start

- A relaxed hour with your father, maybe over the Thursday coffee.
- Your own picture of his typical week.
- Anything he's said about what he'd hate to lose. You can start with just the conversation.

PROMPT 1

Get ready for a conversation, not a form

WHY THIS MATTERS

Nobody opens up to a checklist. The best material comes from stories: what he did this morning, who he ran into, what he'd never give up. Good questions get you there.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What you already know about his days, so the questions fit him.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I want to talk with my father about what an ordinary day holds for him, while he's well and nothing is changing. Here is what I already know about his routines and the people in his week:

> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Give me ten open questions in everyday language that invite stories rather than yes-or-no answers, grouped under MORNINGS, MEALTIMES, AFTERNOONS, EVENINGS, and PEOPLE. Lean toward what I don't already know. Add two questions that gently ask what he would hate to lose, and one that asks how he usually lets people know when he'd rather not do something. Keep it to questions; don't guess the answers.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Questions you'd be comfortable asking over coffee.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Have the conversation. Take notes afterward, not during.

PROMPT 2

Turn the conversation into a routine map

WHY THIS MATTERS

After the talk you'll have stories, half-sentences, and a few surprises. Sorting them while they're fresh keeps his version from blending into yours.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Your notes from the conversation.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I talked with my father about his ordinary days. Here are my notes, including some of my own impressions:
>
> [PASTE YOUR NOTES]
>
> Sort everything into these lists: FAMILIAR ROUTINES, with the time of day each belongs to; PEOPLE AND CONTACT, who he sees or calls and how often; FOOD AND MEALTIMES, his likes, dislikes, and timing only; THINGS HE'D RATHER NOT DO; and WHAT HE'D HATE TO LOSE. Beside each item, write HIM if it came from something he said and US if it came from my impression. Where my notes contradict each other or he gave two different answers, note both rather than choosing.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How many items are marked US. Those are the ones to check.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the HIM items back to him and ask if you got them right.

PROMPT 3

Notice what you've only written as tasks

WHY THIS MATTERS

Left to ourselves, we write care plans about meals, pills, and showers. Those matter. But a day made only of tasks isn't a day he'd recognize. This prompt looks for the life in between.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The lists from the last prompt.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the routine map I've made for my father:
>
> [PASTE THE LISTS FROM PROMPT 2]
>
> Go through it and mark each item as either PRACTICAL, meaning a task that has to happen such as a meal or an appointment, or PERSONAL, meaning something that makes the day feel like his. Tell me if any part of the day is all practical with nothing personal in it. Then list areas of ordinary life I haven't touched at all, for example music, faith or quiet time, pets, being outdoors, the news, naps, humor, or who he talks to when something goes wrong. Return those as things to ask him, not as answers.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A stretch of the day with nothing personal in it.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Pick two of the untouched areas and ask about them next time you're together.

PROMPT 4

Write the Ordinary Day page, with a date on it

WHY THIS MATTERS

Preferences change. The cafe closes, a friend moves, he discovers he likes the radio after all. A page with a date and a check-again line is honest about that. A page without one quietly becomes a rule.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The results of the first three prompts.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything from the first three prompts about what an ordinary good day holds for my father:
>
> [PASTE THE RESULTS OF PROMPTS 1 TO 3]
>
> Write a one-page profile titled AN ORDINARY DAY FOR DAD with these headings: MORNINGS; MEALS, as preferences only, with no dietary or medical instructions; AFTERNOONS AND ACTIVITIES; PEOPLE; EVENINGS AND SLEEP; and HOW HE SAYS NO. Use his own words wherever I've given them. Mark any item he said might change with the words “for now.” Finish with two lines: Written on, with today's date, and Ask again by, left blank for me. Do not add preferences I haven't given you, and do not suggest care arrangements or activities.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page your father would read and say, yes, that's me.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Give him a copy. Put the ask-again date, about a year out, somewhere you'll see it.

Keep the whole of him in one place

The routines you've written down deserve company. The care interview asks about your father's health, home, support, and daily life in one sitting and produces a Family Care Profile, so the person you've described is there when planning gets practical.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›